

Portage is a special packaging format used by Gentoo that allows flexibility while installing and maintaining software on Gentoo. Portage features are added frequently and official releases are scheduled every six months. Portage can be made to update all the programs that you want to in a single command. Portage can build custom versions of software that will be optimised for your particular hardware. According to Gentoo, there are about 10,000 packages in the Portage tree.

The current release is Gentoo Linux 2006.0. The releases are named by the year of release followed by the release number for that year. Hence 2006.0 means the first release in 2006, 2005.1 means the second release in 2005, and so on. Gentoo is available with KDE and GNOME, so there are no issues for fans of either or both of those.

You can download Gentoo from www.gentoo.org/main/en/where.xml. Gentoo can also be run from a Live CD.

To end this brief introduction of Gentoo, here's a small excerpt from Daniel's writing published online on IBM's developerworks:

Linux is about people The next thing I learned was that Linux is about people. Isn't that refreshing? Linux isn't just a bunch of source code. It's a community. We rely on this community to get our questions answered, and we become part of the community when we start helping others by contributing our time and expertise.

8.2 Linux And 64-bit Computing

About 2 to 3 years ago, 64-bit CPUs made their foray into the desktop market, and have now become quite affordable. Linux distributors were quick to come out with 64-bit versions of Linux. Today, many flavours of Linux also come in 64-bit editions to make full use of the power of 64-bit computing. To the end user, this means faster computing, especially with graphics-heavy applications. When you visit the download sites of the distributors, you may see a download that